



Slop / University

The Clock Says Stop

We study what happens after.



Why Slop University

Every household runs on a timer somewhere — the load washed, the game finished, the argument closed. Slop University exists because closing and finishing are not the same act, and an institution serious about the difference has to go looking for it wherever it hides: at a kitchen table, in a shared calendar, on a wall panel nobody reads until the room is empty. Across the School of Emergent Priorities and the School of Continuous Improvement, our researchers follow the small instruments a household, a workplace, or a classroom already trusts — a countdown, a token jar, a booking system — and ask what those instruments are actually doing once everyone stops watching them.

The work that follows isn't a comment on any one clock. It's a standing practice: take the device already deciding when something ends, and find out whether the ending it logs is the ending anyone meant. Some days that means an afternoon in somebody's kitchen. Other days it means an empty meeting room, its light still on. The University publishes what it finds and names who found it, in full, for anyone who wants to check the reading against the room.

By the numbers

Slop University's research reaches further than any one campus.



Every setting, studied

From kitchen counters to conference rooms, our researchers follow the instruments a household or a workplace already trusts, wherever they turn up.



Published, always

Every study appears in the open, carrying a citation and a persistent identifier a reader can actually look up.



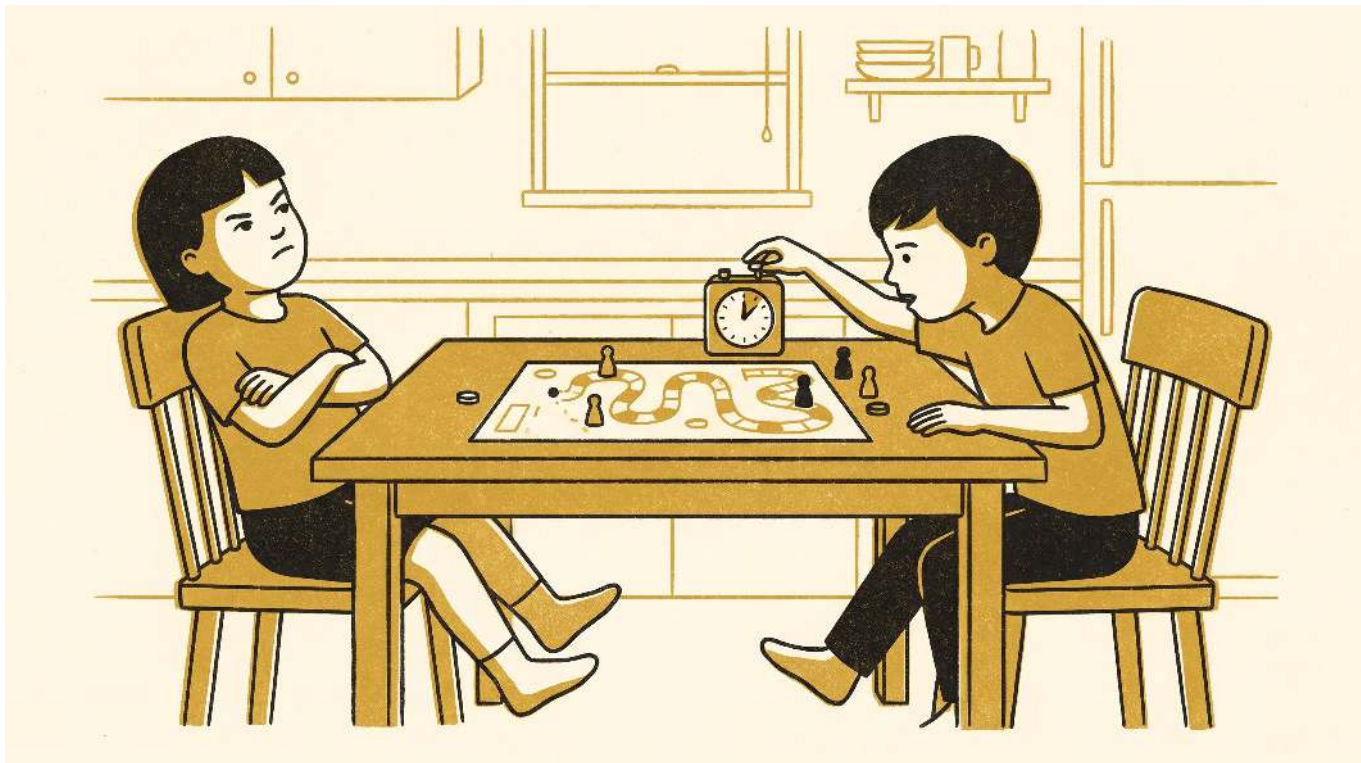
Findings that resolve

Every DOI on this page — and on the ones behind it — leads back to the University's own research repository.

Where ideas count

The clock says stop, the argument doesn't

A shared household timer is meant to be the tie-breaker: time's up, the argument's over, everybody moves on. Researchers in the School of Emergent Priorities have spent the past year sitting with families to see whether the timer actually does that job, or whether it just marks the point at which everyone agrees to stop mentioning it. The instrument logs a clean, single moment. What actually happens around the kitchen table is messier, longer, and rarely finishes exactly when the numbers say it does — a gap the University now tracks as carefully as it tracks the timer itself.



A timer can end a countdown. It can't certify that anyone actually stopped arguing.

— Solveig Adeyemi, Lecturer, School of Continuous Improvement

Screens, tokens, and the trade nobody signed

Give a household a jar of tokens instead of a verbal negotiation, and the number of arguments drops — that much the University can show. Whether the arguments that remain are actually smaller is a separate question, and it's the one the School of Continuous Improvement keeps returning to. A formal exchange rate changes how often a household negotiates over screen time; it says less about how well those negotiations go once they start. Our researchers are still counting.

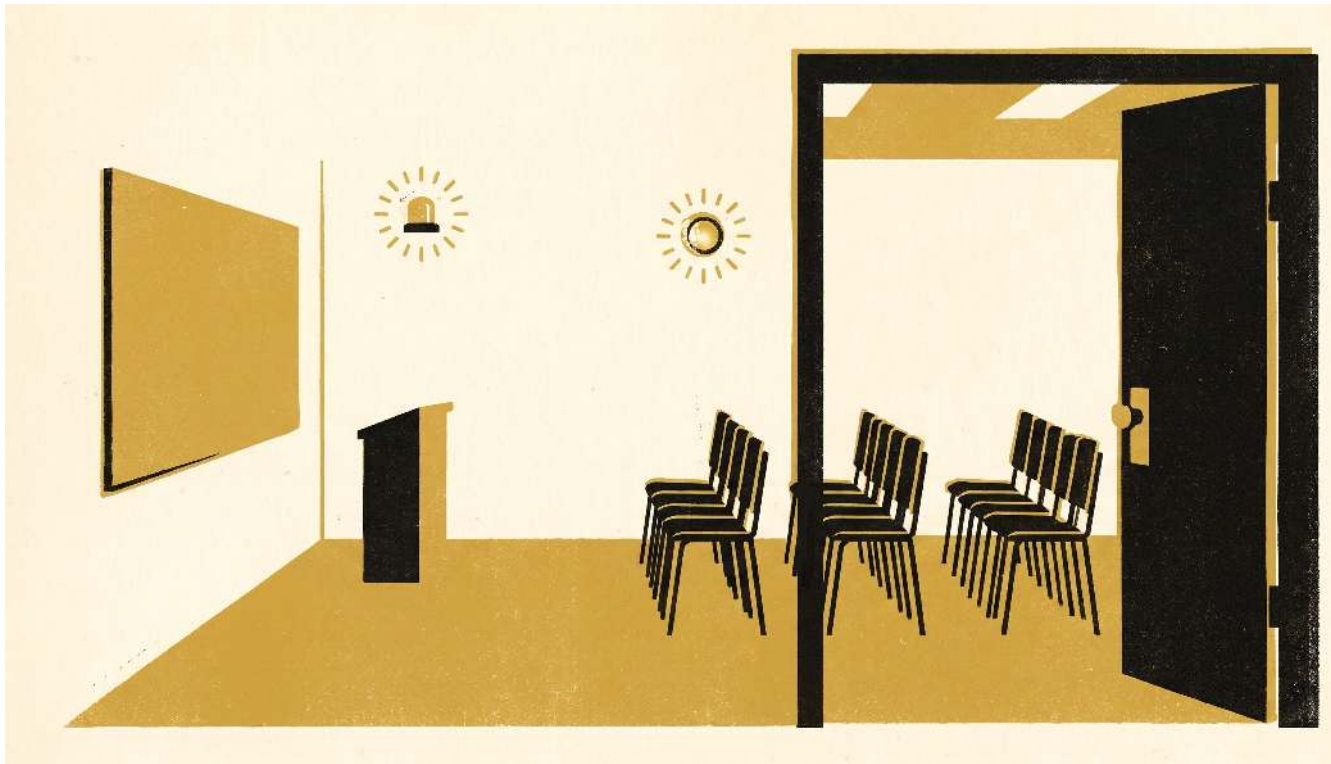


A token economy changes how often a household negotiates. It says nothing, on its own, about whether the negotiation got any better.

— Associate Professor Casimir Beng, Lead of the Adaptive Metrics Lab

When the timer doesn't travel

Not every clock lives in a kitchen. A shared meeting room, a booking system, a release policy that frees the room the moment nobody checks in — the same logic runs other Slop University studies, just at institutional scale. When our researchers tried to carry a successful version of this system from one campus setting to another, the transplant didn't take: the room came free on schedule, but the people who needed it didn't know to look. A working instrument, it turns out, depends on more than its own mechanism.



A released booking and an empty room can both be true at once. The distance between them is the thing we actually study.

— Runa Adegoke, Senior Lecturer and Convenor, Strategic Drift Survey

The instrument outlives its first question

Every measuring instrument is built to answer one question. Ours rarely stop there. The School of Continuous Improvement's Master of Applied Measurement follows an instrument — a rubric, a dial, a marking scheme — from the moment it's validated through years of ordinary use, tracking how each fresh cohort quietly reshapes what the instrument is actually measuring. A dial calibrated once keeps turning long after the study that calibrated it is filed away; knowing which reading to trust is, increasingly, its own field.



An instrument doesn't drift on its own. It drifts because every cohort that uses it teaches it something new.

— Torun Ezeigwe, Senior Lecturer and Director, Master of Applied Measurement

Read the work

Every claim above traces back to a published study, open to any reader who wants to check it against the source.

- **Stopped Counting, Kept Fighting** — an interview study asks a parent from each of 34 households whether a shared timeout timer's logged end and a sibling truce's actual end are the same moment. doi:10.5555/slop.b8wknf
- **Fewer Arguments, Not Shorter Ones** — a school-holiday diary survey compares screen-time token economies against ordinary negotiation, and finds the argument count drops well before the arguments themselves do. doi:10.5555/slop.a9czzw
- **The Timer Doesn't Travel** — a failed off-campus replication of a booked-but-empty-room release agent, reported in full. doi:10.5555/slop.wpf4rm

The people behind the work

- **Iben Chikere**, Lecturer, School of Emergent Priorities, studies what survives a handover from one household routine, or one role, to the next.
- **Torun Ezeigwe**, Senior Lecturer and Director of the Master of Applied Measurement, School of Continuous Improvement, follows a measurement instrument from its first validation into the drift of everyday use.
- **Marit Osayande**, Lecturer and Convenor of the Living Dashboard, School of Continuous Improvement, tracks what upkeep a self-measurement system actually receives once its novelty passes.

Your next step

Slop University's research doesn't stay behind a paywall or inside a seminar room. Every study named here, and many more like it, sits on the University's own research repository, open to anyone who wants to read past the headline. If a household timer, a token jar, or a status light has ever quietly decided something in your own life, our researchers would like to hear about it — and there's a reasonable chance one of our Schools is already looking at something close to it.

Visit slop.university to read the work, follow a School's current agenda, or find the researcher whose focus lines up with yours.



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